

Arthritis Flare-Up: What to Do When Symptoms Get Worse

Flare-ups are one of the most frustrating parts of arthritis. Learn how to recognise, manage, and recover from them with confidence.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Arthritis Flare-Up: What to Do



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A flare-up is a sudden increase in disease activity — more pain, more swelling, more stiffness, more fatigue. They can last hours, days, or weeks, and they can strike even when you've been managing your condition well.

Recognising a Flare-Up

Common signs include: - **Increased joint pain** that doesn't respond to your usual measures - **Morning stiffness** lasting longer than 30 minutes (or significantly longer than your baseline) - **Swelling, warmth, or redness** in one or more joints - **Fatigue** that feels disproportionate to your activity level - **Difficulty with tasks** you normally manage

Immediate Steps (First 24–48 Hours)



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1. Rest — but don't stop completely Protect the affected joints, but gentle movement prevents stiffness from worsening. Think "modify, don't stop."

****2. Apply cold for swelling, heat for stiffness**** - Ice packs (wrapped in a cloth) for 15 minutes to reduce acute swelling - Heat pads or warm baths for stiffness and muscle tension - Alternate if you have both symptoms

****3. Review your medication**** If you have a "flare plan" from your rheumatologist, follow it. This might include a short course of anti-inflammatory medication or a temporary increase in pain relief. Never exceed recommended doses without medical advice.

****4. Prioritise sleep**** Flare-ups worsen with poor sleep. Use pillows to support painful joints, keep the room cool, and consider a warm bath before bed.



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Days 3–7: Active Recovery

- ****Gentle stretching:**** 5–10 minutes twice daily to maintain range of motion

- **Anti-inflammatory nutrition:** Increase omega-3 rich foods (salmon, mackerel, walnuts), reduce sugar and processed foods
- **Hydration:** Dehydration increases joint pain sensitivity
- **Pacing:** Use the 50% rule — do half of what you think you can manage

When to Contact Your GP or Rheumatologist

- Flare lasts more than 7–10 days without improvement
- You develop a fever alongside joint symptoms (could indicate infection)
- A single joint becomes very hot, red, and swollen (rule out septic arthritis)
- You're unable to perform basic daily tasks
- Your mental health is significantly affected

Preventing Future Flare-Ups

- **Identify triggers:** Common ones include stress, overexertion, weather changes, poor sleep, and illness
- **Keep a symptom diary:** Note activities, food, stress levels, and weather alongside symptoms
- **Maintain medication consistency:** Skipping doses is one of the most common flare triggers
- **Build rest into your routine:** Don't wait until you're exhausted

Key Takeaway

Flare-ups are not a sign of failure. They're a normal part of living with arthritis. Having a clear plan means you can respond quickly and recover faster.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about arthritis flare-up: what to do when symptoms get worse?

Short answer: An arthritis flare-up is a sudden increase in symptoms like joint pain, swelling, stiffness, and fatigue, lasting hours, days, or weeks. Immediate steps involve rest, applying cold for swelling or heat for stiffness, reviewing medication according to a flare plan, and prioritising sleep. If a flare lasts over 7-10 days, or if you develop fever, contact your doctor.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk